I did not have to speak anymore; there was unanimity that the project can go out of Kerala.

The selection team visited all the shortlisted sites, and Balasore and Mahendragiri emerged as most favoured. Balasore was scarcely populated and comprised mostly non-agriculture land; it was secluded and safe. Mahendragiri was on the eastern foothills of the tail-end of the Western Ghats, much greener than Balasore. A place called Podigai, by a hill south of the Mahendragiri hill looked ideal for the test stand, but there were some villages which need to be evacuated. I favoured Mahendragiri for its proximity to Trivandrum. Balasore was more than 2,000 km away, Mahendragiri a little more than 100 km.

'Balasore is an ideal place for carrying out tests, but it is too far from VSSC and the propulsion centre,' I said. 'You can't have the brain in Trivandrum and the hands in Balasore.'

Today, when technology has enabled us to work in tandem sitting in different continents, this argument may sound silly, but in those days it was indeed tough to coordinate between two centres so apart. Besides the difficulty in transporting materials across the distance, testing, too, needed frequent shuttling between the two places. There are some 300 parameters that need to be monitored and communicated between the centres, and in those days the landline was the fastest mode of communication.

Some parameters, during the test, may not conform to the ideal, but it is virtually impossible to launch a rocket with all the parameters of all the systems reporting ideal performance. The accepted practice is that even if some parameters of a sub-sub-system are not accurate, and if the end system works within the margin of accuracy and consistency, the system is approved. This, however, involved much to-and-fro communication and visits by the quality control team, and paper work by the non-conformance board. So, Mahendragiri it would be.

The positive outcome of our Balasore survey was the establishment of the integrated missile test range later in 1989. Chandipur-on-sea in Balasore district is, today, India's only test launch pad from where Agni, Prithvi and all other missiles take off.